

Parks Board Meeting March 17, 2026

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_WvsgUMSHTU
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Muncie Park and Recreation Board Meeting Summary

Meeting Date: March 17

Presiding Officer: Nick (Board President / Presiding Officer)

1. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order:** Called to order by the presiding officer on Tuesday, March 17. The meeting opened with the Pledge of Allegiance.
- **Attendance:**
 - *Present:* C.J. Johnson, Shannon Powers, Brad Marshall, and (joining late) Mark Ervin.
 - *Absent / Remote:* Ashley Gray (attending remotely from home due to being under the weather).
 - *New Member Welcome:* The board welcomed new member C.J. Johnson to his first meeting.

2. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** The meeting opened with the Pledge of Allegiance.

- **Approval of Minutes:** The minutes from the February meeting were presented, with no discussion or revisions, and approved by voice vote.
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3. Substantive Business & Board Action

00:02:09 5-Year Master Plan RFQ Presentations

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Board leadership / City administration.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The board heard presentations from four engineering/design firms responding to the Request for Qualifications (RFQs) for the city's upcoming 5-Year Parks and Recreation Master Plan update. The master plan is required by the IDNR to qualify for federal and state grants. Each firm presented their qualifications, portfolio, and approach to community engagement and equity. Following the presentations, board members were instructed to complete their selections and rankings by Thursday to pass to the city engineer on Friday.
 - **Presenting Firms:**
 1. **REA (Rundell Ernstberger Associates):** Presented by Cecil Penland and Kyle Koger. Highlighted their long history in Muncie (since 1978), multi-disciplinary staff (engineers, landscape architects, urban planners), local residency, and prior work on Muncie projects (Cornerstone Park, Canan Commons, Muncie Memorial Spiral, Westside Skate Park).
 2. **Flatland Resources:** Presented by David Heilman and Kurt Stagemiller. Emphasized their deep local roots in Muncie, extensive work on the Cardinal and White River Greenways, previous grant acquisition successes, and ongoing collection of community engagement data over the past two years.
 3. **Framework Planning and Design:** Presented by David Arbester, joined by Josh Ferks (USI Consultants) and Austin Hostetler (Zeigler Insights). Highlighted their scalable approach, data-driven methodology (Zeigler Insights), GIS mapping integration (USI), and experience with organizational management and IDNR master plans.
 4. **American Structure Point:** Presented by Luke Kessler and Lisa Donaway. Highlighted their full-service engineering and landscape architecture team, strong established relationship with IDNR staff, and local Muncie resident representation on the team.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Informational presentations only; no formal vote taken during this session. Individual board rankings to be submitted by Thursday.
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01:13:00 Mary's Miles 5K Fundraiser Event Approval & Fee Request

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Nikki (Department staff).

- **Deliberation Summary:** The board reviewed an application for the 3rd annual “Mary’s Miles” 5K fundraiser, scheduled for August 8 from 6:00 a.m. to 2:00 p.m. at Westside Park, expecting approximately 200 participants. The organizers requested the use of shelters 3 and 4, open park bathrooms, and the delivery of two ADA portable toilets. Staff recommended providing one city ADA portable toilet while charging normal fees for the shelter, leaving organizers to cover any additional portable toilet costs.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote.
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01:15:45 Southside Neighborhood Association <U+2013> Gus Macker Basketball Tournament Equipment Request

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Nikki (Department staff).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The Southside Neighborhood Association requested the use of three-rise black bleachers, 8-foot folding tables, and chairs for the upcoming Gus Macker basketball tournament (scheduled for May 17<U+2013>19). Organizers requested a fee waiver for the equipment, offering in-kind sponsorship benefits (such as banner placement and commercials) valued at approximately \$1,000 in lieu of rental fees. The event is expected to draw 200 teams (71% youth participants).
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote to waive equipment rental fees in exchange for sponsorship/advertising.
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4. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- **01:33:40 Roger Ditmyer:** Spoke as the organizer of the Catfish Pirates fishing tournament and representative of Amvets Post 12. Expressed deep concern regarding the recent doubling of boat ramp fees at Prairie Creek Reservoir (from \$15 to \$30). He stated that while his veteran fundraiser tournament will proceed this year, the increased fees risk driving participants away to state-operated lakes, ultimately reducing funds raised for local veterans.
 - **01:39:49 Wayne Skate:** Addressed the board as a local resident and Prairie Creek lake user. Questioned the reasoning behind the steep hikes across all park fees at Prairie Creek, noting that price increases are harming regular visitors and local boaters. Department leadership briefly reiterated that rate adjustments were established in September to offset projected revenue losses resulting from attrition and campground/dock reductions tied to water company discussions.
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5. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Superintendent / Staff Reports:**

- **Chris (Parks Maintenance):** Reported that three compromised shelters at Allshire, McCulloch, and Tuhey Parks were removed and replaced due to safety concerns. Crews are actively performing spring cleaning (painting, repairing picnic tables, clearing debris). The mechanic's workshop has successfully relocated to Centennial, and cemetery/park teams have consolidated locations to improve operational efficiency. Nate Burgess was hired as the new department mechanic.
- **Nikki (Programming & Events):** Noted that the department received 116 applications for 50 summer internship positions; interviews are currently being scheduled. Planning is underway for "National Kids to the Park Day" on May 16 (12:00<U+2013>4:00 p.m.) at Westside Park.
- **Shannon Powers (Grants & 501c3 Update):** Announced that the newly formed 501(c)(3) nonprofit<U+2014>*Muncie Alliance for Parks and Sustainability*<U+2014>has officially received its EIN number, which will open new grant application channels. Applications for recreation funding have been submitted to the Ball Brothers Foundation (\$30,000) and a Bridgestone tire grant (\$10,000).
- **Taylor Beard & Grace Taylor (Prairie Creek Reservoir):** Introduced Grace Taylor as the new administrative coordinator. Reported that dock installations have faced weather delays due to strong winds but are expected to resume. The dock lottery is scheduled for the week of April 6 (deadline March 31). Advanced security features (keycard/app access and cameras) are being installed at the campground bathhouse to curb vandalism. Quotes for new diesel mowers and utility vehicles are being finalized.
- **Old Business:** The board noted that ongoing discussions regarding quotes, equipment updates, and management structure for the Tuhey Pool for the upcoming season are still underway.
- **Adjournment:**
 - **Action:** Motion to adjourn passed by voice vote.
 - **Time:** Meeting concluded.